customized this way. Mr John Hodgson, the Chief Locomotive Engineer, East Indian Railway, started the process, but it was eventually completed by two Calcutta-based coach-building firms—Messrs Stewart and Company, and Seton and Company. However, the locomotives or engines arriving for the EIR also met a somewhat similar fate. An archival report states that the ship carrying the locomotives went to the continent of Australia instead of reaching India. [31] Finally, the locomotive reached Calcutta via Australia by HMS Dekagree in 1854, but by then, it was too late to compete with Bombay. The first passenger train had been run in Bombay a year earlier and the EIR had missed making history!

On 28 June 1854, Mr Hodgson and his team took a trial trip from Howrah to Pundooah. The railway was opened as far as Hooghly, a distance of 24 miles, on 15 August, and up to Pundooah on 1 September 1854. On Saturday, 3 February 1855, the line was opened up to Raniganj, as originally planned. [32]

The delays in opening the sections were due to a few other reasons too. There was a boundary problem with France, as Chandernagore was under French control, and tracks were found to be encroaching on its boundary. Further, the line was reported to have displaced houses, gardens and even religious structures, generating opposition, which delayed the opening of the line.

The following four news reports of that time give a peek into the town's public sentiment and how difficult it must have been for the railway workers on the ground to get the work done.

'No Compensation'

The *Calcutta Chronicle* learns that the 'first sod' of the Great Indian Railway has been actually turned; and the work commenced in right earnest. Trees, plants, houses, that seemed to have fallen within the line of the expected railroad, are now being removed, and the inhabitants of the neighbouring villages at Bailee, Wooterparah, Sulkeah [33] & C., are loud in their complaints, as no compensation is now offered them for the injuries sustained in consequence. The local magistrates say they do not entertain complaints proffered against the railway pioneers, but recommend them to apply to the government on the subject of the damages done.

Woman in Childbirth Not Spared

The Hurkaru states that the railway contractors have already cleared the line between Howrah and Serampore, but heavy complaints are made by the native population, whose